

Animal Farm

A Fairy Story — George Orwell, 1945

A revolution against a cruel master that slowly **becomes the very tyranny it overthrew**. Orwell is writing about how power corrupts and how **controlling the story — the words, the history — is how the powerful keep everyone else in line**. Keep that in mind and every scene lines up behind it.

The story in a paragraph

The animals of Manor Farm, half-starved under drunken **Mr. Jones**, are stirred by old **Major**'s dream of a world where animals rule themselves. They rebel, drive Jones out, rename it **Animal Farm**, and paint **Seven Commandments** on the barn wall — the first principle being "All animals are equal." Two pigs, **Napoleon** and **Snowball**, compete to lead, until Napoleon uses a pack of dogs he raised in secret to drive Snowball out and seize total power. From there the pigs slowly take on every human vice — sleeping in beds, drinking, trading with humans — and each time, **Squealer** quietly rewrites a commandment to make it look allowed. The loyal workhorse **Boxer** is worked to collapse and then sold to the glue-maker for drink money. By the end the pigs walk on two legs and dine with humans, and the other animals, looking from pig to man, "cannot tell which is which."

Who's who (the ones that carry a theme)

- **Old Major** — the wise old pig whose speech sparks the rebellion; the idealist who dreams the dream but dies before it's twisted.
- **Napoleon** — the pig who seizes power and becomes a dictator worse than Jones. Rules by force and fear.
- **Snowball** — the clever, sincere pig who actually wants to improve the farm; driven out and then blamed for everything.
- **Squealer** — Napoleon's smooth-talking mouthpiece who rewrites history and explains away every broken promise.
- **Boxer** — the strong, faithful horse whose answer to everything is "I will work harder." The good, trusting worker who is used up and betrayed.
- **Benjamin** — the old donkey who sees exactly what's happening and says nothing. The danger of staying silent.
- **The Dogs & the Sheep** — the enforcers who silence dissent, and the crowd who chant slogans without thinking.

Themes at a glance

- **Power corrupts** — those who seize power to end oppression become the new oppressors.
- **Propaganda & rewriting history** — control the words and you control what people believe is true.
- **Blind obedience** — the sheep chant, Boxer trusts, and no one stops to question.
- **The danger of staying silent** — Benjamin sees the truth but never speaks, and it costs everyone.
- **Ideals twisted to serve the powerful** — "All animals are equal" quietly becomes "some are more equal."
- **History repeats** — by the end the pigs are indistinguishable from the humans they replaced.

The themes in depth

Power corrupts

The revolution begins with a genuinely good dream — animals free from a cruel master. But the moment the pigs hold power, they start bending it toward themselves: better food, private privileges, then rule by fear. Orwell's point isn't that the cause was wrong; it's that power without accountability rots even those who started with good intentions. Napoleon doesn't fix the injustice — he simply moves into Jones's house.

Propaganda & rewriting history

Squealer is the most dangerous animal on the farm, and he never lifts a hoof in violence. He works with *words* — sneaking out at night to change the commandments on the barn wall, "proving" with numbers that the animals are better off, insisting they misremember what they plainly saw. When you control the story, you control what people accept as true. The farm falls not just to force but to a steady stream of confident lies.

Blind obedience

The sheep drown out debate by bleating slogans they don't understand. Boxer, the best-hearted animal on the farm, answers every problem with "I will work harder" and "Napoleon is always right" — and his loyalty is exactly what gets him destroyed. Orwell shows that good, hard-working, trusting people can be the easiest to exploit when they stop asking questions.

The danger of staying silent

Benjamin the donkey is the one animal who understands everything from the start. He can read; he sees the commandments being changed; he knows what the glue truck means. And he does nothing until it's too late to save Boxer. His silence is its own kind of choice — a warning that seeing the truth means little if you won't act on it.

Ideals twisted to serve the powerful

Every commandment starts as a clean principle and ends with a quiet loophole: no animal shall sleep in a bed becomes "...with sheets"; no animal shall kill another becomes "...without cause." The famous last version says it plainly — "All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others." The words of the revolution are kept; their meaning is hollowed out.

History repeats

In the final scene the pigs walk upright, wear clothes, carry whips, and share a friendly drink with the neighboring farmers. The animals outside look "from pig to man, and from man to pig," and can no longer tell the difference. The whole cycle has come around: the oppressed became the oppressor, and nothing really changed for the ones at the bottom.

Passages to slow down on

- Old Major's opening speech — the pure version of the dream, before anyone twists it.
- Napoleon unleashing the dogs to drive out Snowball — the exact moment persuasion turns into force.
- The commandments on the barn wall quietly gaining new words — reread them side by side.
- Boxer being led away in the knacker's van while Squealer insists it's a hospital.
- The final scene — pigs and humans at the same table, indistinguishable.

"All animals are equal, but some animals are more equal than others."

— Animal Farm

3 questions to ask

- 1 The animals started with "All animals are equal." How did the pigs slowly change that — and why did the other animals go along with it?
- 2 Benjamin saw exactly what was happening but never spoke up. When is staying silent the wrong choice, and what should he have done?
- 3 The book warns that people who grab power often become the very thing they fought against. What does that teach us about how power should be used — and about putting our trust in God rather than in people who promise us everything?

